

Setting-Up Your Own Personal Home Cloud



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With the proliferation of devices like mobile phones and tablets, we find that photos and videos that we shoot are not easily shareable. Many times we want to play music that we heard at home outside on our mobile or tablet, but forget to copy the song to the device. Or, we have a guest at home with whom we want to share our photos taken during our last vacation, but the photos are on the tablet that we left at office.

What if we have a central storage for all media files (photos, videos and music) that are already available or stored on different devices, so that these files are accessible on not only the devices on the home broadband network but anywhere in the world? A network access storage (NAS) drive with home Cloud set-up is the answer.

What is an NAS drive

An NAS drive is a high-capacity drive (2-4TB) with an on-board processor that runs a server, which allows it to stream media files to any compatible device(s) on the network. These NAS drives, unlike conventional drives, have a LAN interface and connect to a network router. Any device on the network, with access permissions, can access files on this drive. These drives also support media streaming to DLNA-compatible televisions.

You might ask why not use Sky-

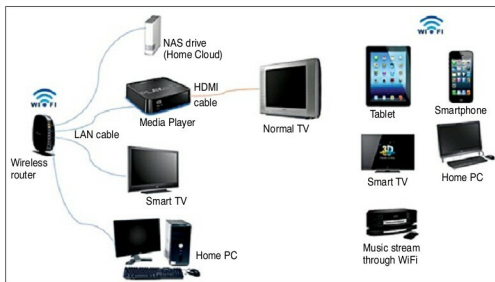


Fig. 1: A typical home Cloud set-up

Drive or iCloud or DropBox storage, which is easily accessible? The answer is, these services offer limited storage free of charge, beyond which they charge a monthly fee. Plus, you may not feel secure since these files are located at a remote location.

Minimum requirement to set-up a home Cloud

First, you need a good, reliable broadband connection with at least 2Mbps speed. Many operators have schemes based on your bandwidth requirement. You can get a package for under ₹ 1000 per month, which includes rental and broadband usage (some operators even provide free credit of voice-calls on the landline). The operator provides the modem and, at an added cost, you can get a Wi-Fi router as well. But many times, these are not from a good brand. I would suggest buying a modem with a built-in wireless router. When selecting wireless features in the router, look for dual-band. Belkin N600DB modem router is a popular brand and known to be of good quality. Do not

compromise on quality just to save money.

After setting-up your broadband connection through a router, connect all your smartphones and tablets on the network.

If you have a smart TV, connect this to the network as well. If not, invest in a media player as explained in the next section.

Now, install the NAS drive. Western Digital My Cloud is a known and reliable brand with good local technical support. A 3TB NAS drive should be available under ₹ 10,000. Connect this to your router using a LAN cable.

The next step is to store all media files, including photos, videos and music, in a public folder under respective directories. The NAS drive can also be used to back-up files on your PCs, laptops and tablets.

A typical home Cloud set-up with connected devices is shown in Fig. 1.

What if you do not own a smart television

If you have an old television that does not have a network interface, you can